

RRB NTPC & SSC CGL Master Practice Sheet

Syllabus Focus: Ancient Indian History & Himalayan Drainage System (Updated with SSC CGL 2025 Targets)

Question 1: Mahajanapadas and Capitals (PYQ Baseline)

Match the following Ancient Mahajanapadas with their respective capital cities as referenced in early Buddhist and Jain texts:

1. Chedi - Shuktimati
2. Vatsa - Kaushambi
3. Assaka - Potana
4. Matsya - Indraprastha

Which of the above pairs are correctly matched?

- A) 1, 2 and 4 only
- B) 3 and 4 only
- C) 1, 2 and 3 only
- D) All of the above

Correct Answer: C) 1, 2 and 3 only

Explanation: Pairs 1, 2, and 3 are perfectly correct. Chedi's capital was Shuktimati, Vatsa was based at Kaushambi, and Assaka (Asmaka), located on the banks of the Godavari river, had its capital at Potana (or Potali). Pair 4 is incorrectly matched because the capital of Matsya Mahajanapada was Viratnagar (Bairat), whereas Indraprastha served as the ancient capital city of the Kuru Mahajanapada.

Exam Source & Pattern Logic: 30% Category: Previous Year Question (PYQ) Baseline. Pattern matched with standard historical matching parameters frequently used by centralized boards to evaluate core territorial literacy.

Question 2: Mauryan Empire and Ashokan Edicts (High-Frequency PYQ)

Who among the following British archaeologists was the first to decipher the Brahmi script of Ashokan Edicts in 1837?

- A) John Marshall
- B) William Jones
- C) James Prinsep
- D) Alexander Cunningham

Correct Answer: C) James Prinsep

Explanation: James Prinsep, an English antiquarian and colonial administrator, successfully deciphered the ancient Brahmi script found on Ashokan pillars and edicts. This breakthrough officially unveiled Emperor Ashoka's historical achievements to modern scholarship.

Exam Source & Pattern Logic: 30% Category: Highly Repeated Core PYQ Baseline. Highly repeated in RRB NTPC (2016, 2021) and SSC CGL Tier-1 shifts.

Question 3: Himalayan River System (From SSC CGL 2025 All-Set Banks)

Which of the following pairs accurately maps the modern Himalayan rivers of the Indus basin to their ancient Rigvedic names as featured in recent SSC CGL 2025 shifts?

1. Jhelum — Vitasta
 2. Chenab — Asikni
 3. Ravi — Purushni
 4. Sutlej — Sutudri
- A) 1 and 3 only
B) 2, 3, and 4 only
C) 1, 2, and 4 only
D) All of the above

Correct Answer: D) All of the above

Explanation: This question directly mirrors the exact Rigvedic river-mapping match matrices that appeared in the 2025 CGL General Awareness papers. All four pairings are historically accurate.

Exam Source & Pattern Logic: *New Addition: Taken directly from SSC CGL 2025 Tier-1 (September/October shifts) to target modern mapping vectors.*

Question 4: Post-Mauryan Period - Dynastic Developments (SSC CGL 2025 Shift-Pattern)

Consider the following statements regarding the Post-Mauryan socio-political and economic dynamics:

Statement-I: The Satavahana rulers predominantly issued lead, potin, copper, and silver coins, reflecting a flourishing agrarian and metallurgic economy in the Deccan.

Statement-II: The Indo-Greek rulers were the first in India to issue coins that can be definitely attributed to specific kings, featuring portraits and bilingual legends.

- A) Both Statement-I and Statement-II are correct.
B) Both Statement-I and Statement-II are incorrect.
C) Statement-I is correct, but Statement-II is incorrect.
D) Statement-I is incorrect, but Statement-II is correct.

Correct Answer: A) Both Statement-I and Statement-II are correct.

Explanation: Both statements are completely accurate. The Satavahanas are historically unique for extensively minting lead and potin (a base alloy) coins alongside their silver currency to manage active regional trade. Meanwhile, the Indo-Greek kings revolutionized Indian coinage during the post-Mauryan era by introducing highly stylized individualized portraits and bilingual legends (typically Greek and Kharosthi/Brahmi) that definitively linked currency to individual rulers.

Exam Source & Pattern Logic: *20% Category: SSC CGL 2025 Shift-Pattern. Follows the analytical multi-statement structure normalized in Tier-1 and Tier-2 general awareness sections to test conceptual depth rather than quick memory.*

Question 5: Himalayan Drainage System - Structural Topography (SSC CGL 2025 Shift-Pattern)

Which of the following statements about the antecedent nature and structural path of Himalayan rivers is accurate?

- A) Himalayan rivers are classified as subsequent drainage because they originated entirely after the final uplift of the mountain ranges.
- B) The Indus cuts a massive deep gorge near Skardu exclusively within the Lesser Himalayan zone without crossing the Zaskar range.
- C) The Tsangpo-Brahmaputra takes a hairpin 'great bend' around the eastern extremity of the Himalayas at Namcha Barwa before entering India as the Siang/Dihang.
- D) The Sutlej originates within the Rohtang Pass in Himachal Pradesh and flows eastward before turning west into Tibet.

Correct Answer: C) The Tsangpo-Brahmaputra takes a hairpin 'great bend' around the eastern extremity of the Himalayas at Namcha Barwa before entering India as the Siang/Dihang.

Explanation: Statement C is perfectly correct. The Brahmaputra (originating as the Yarlung Tsangpo in Tibet) follows an easterly course parallel to the Himalayas and, upon reaching the eastern syntaxial bend at the peak of Namcha Barwa, performs a dramatic hairpin turn to carve a deep gorge and enter India. Statement A is wrong because they are antecedent, not subsequent. Statement B is incorrect because the Indus breaks through the deep alpine ranges well beyond the simple lesser zone. Statement D is completely inverted; the Sutlej starts in Tibet and flows west into India via Shipki La.

Exam Source & Pattern Logic: 20% Category: SSC CGL 2025 Shift-Pattern. Mimics the physical-geography structure common in recent shifts, focusing on structural geomorphological traits over simple nominal lookups.

Question 6: Ancient Economic & Agrarian Terminology (Rare Concept)

During the Mahajanapada and early imperial periods (Nanda-Maurya transition), what did the term Bali specifically signify in the context of state revenue and rural economy?

- A) A customary religious/tribute tax originally voluntary in the Vedic era that became a compulsory agricultural imposition during the Mahajanapada phase.
- B) A forced-labor duty (Vishti) exacted strictly from urban artisans in lieu of cash coinage.
- C) An import-export customs duty levied at the city gates by the Shulkadhyaksha.
- D) A special irrigation cess charged from farmers utilizing state-owned reservoir channels (Setubandha).

Correct Answer: A) A customary religious/tribute tax originally voluntary in the Vedic era that became a compulsory agricultural imposition during the Mahajanapada phase.

Explanation: Statement A is correct. In early Vedic times, Bali was a voluntary religious offering presented to the tribal chief (Rajan) or deities. However, by the age of the Mahajanapadas and the emergence of centralized Magadhan tax collection systems, it transformed into a highly structured, compulsory land-revenue tax collected regularly from agricultural peasants by specialized royal collection agents (Bali-sadhakas).

Exam Source & Pattern Logic: 20% Category: Never Highly Repetitive State Content. Specifically targets socio-economic transitions and ancient administrative terminology, skipping over typical dynasty timelines to test real conceptual history.

Question 7: Geomorphological Evolution of Himalayan Drainage (Rare Concept)

The geological hypothesis that explains the pre-Himalayan longitudinal continuity of a single mighty mega-river traversing from Assam to Punjab before tectonic fragmentation fractured it into modern basins is known as:

- A) The Tethys-Gondwana Suture Drainage Model
- B) The Shiwalik-Ganga Dislocation Theory
- C) The Indo-Brahma or Shiwalik River Hypothesis
- D) The Pleistocene Foredeep Capture Hypothesis

Correct Answer: C) The Indo-Brahma or Shiwalik River Hypothesis

Explanation: Statement C is correct. Mid-20th-century geomorphologists proposed the Indo-Brahma (or Shiwalik) River hypothesis. This theory maintains that a single massive continuous river once flowed from Assam all the way west across the base of the emerging Himalayas into the Punjab plains. Tectonic activity during the Pleistocene epoch—specifically the upward tilt of the Potwar plateau and the concurrent down-warping of the Malda Gap—fractured this mega-trough, dividing it into three modern systems: the Indus, Ganga, and Brahmaputra.

Exam Source & Pattern Logic: 20% Category: Never Highly Repetitive State Content. Explores macro-geological evolution and river-system history, targeting deeper regional structures often missed in basic flashcard study guides.

Question 8: Mauryan Empire (From SSC CGL 2025 All-Set Questions)

The Ashokan rock inscriptions discovered in the extreme northwestern regions (such as Kandahar in modern Afghanistan) were uniquely written in which of the following combinations of languages and scripts?

- A) Prakrit language and Brahmi script
- B) Aramaic and Greek languages/scripts
- C) Sanskrit language and Kharosthi script
- D) Pali language and Devanagari script

Correct Answer: B) Aramaic and Greek languages/scripts

Explanation: Ashoka tailored his edicts to local populations. In the far west regions like Kandahar, he utilized Greek and Aramaic scripts and languages to ensure the multicultural border populations could fully comprehend his imperial decrees and policy of Dhamma.

Exam Source & Pattern Logic: New Addition: Taken directly from SSC CGL 2025 Tier-1 Core History sections to align with script variation trends.

Question 9: Post-Mauryan Buddhist Councils & Scholarly Patronage (Tricky & Close Option)

Consider the following statements regarding the Fourth Buddhist Council held during the Post-Mauryan era:

Statement-I: It was convened at Kundalvana in Kashmir under the active patronage of the Kushan emperor Kanishka and presided over by Vasumitra with Ashvaghosa as vice-president.

Statement-II: It resulted in the final authoritative compilation of the Mahavibhasa Shastra and marked the formal consolidation of the sectarian split of Buddhism into Mahayana and Hinayana forms.

- A) Statement-I is correct, but Statement-II is incorrect.
- B) Both Statement-I and Statement-II are incorrect.
- C) Both Statement-I and Statement-II are correct.
- D) Statement-I is incorrect, but Statement-II is correct.

Correct Answer: C) Both Statement-I and Statement-II are correct.

Explanation: Both statements are completely accurate. Under Kanishka's patronage in Kashmir, the Fourth Council systematically organized Buddhist doctrines, writing down the massive Sanskrit commentary known as the Mahavibhasa Shastra. This council solidified the transition of Buddhism into a formal distinct split, with Mahayana expanding significantly under Kushan influence.

Exam Source & Pattern Logic: 30% Category: Tricky & Close Option Configuration. Blends patron-monk names with exact textual products and theological outcomes, ensuring candidates understand both institutional facts and systemic results.

Question 10: Ganga River System (From SSC CGL 2025 All-Set Questions)

Which of the following is a major right-bank tributary of the Ganga River that originates in the Peninsular highlands and flows directly northward to merge with the Ganga mainstream?

- A) Chambal
- B) Betwa
- C) Son
- D) Ken

Correct Answer: C) Son

Explanation: This is a classic centralized examination trap. While the Chambal, Betwa, and Ken rivers all originate in the peninsular plateau and flow northwards, they are actually tributaries of the Yamuna River. Only the Son River flows directly from the Amarkantak plateau northward into the Ganga mainstream itself near Patna.

Exam Source & Pattern Logic: New Addition: Sourced directly from SSC CGL 2025 Tier-1 / Tier-2 transition sets to emphasize hydrologic flow hierarchy.